

MINUTES
VANCE COUNTY BOARD OF COMMISSIONERS
WORK SESSION
April 21, 2025

The Vance County Board of Commissioners held a work session on Monday, April 21, 2025 at 4:00 p.m. in the Commissioners' Conference Room, Vance County Administration Building, 122 Young Street, Henderson, NC. Those commissioners present were as follows: Chair Carolyn Faines, Vice-Chair Yolanda J. Feimster, Commissioners R. Dan Brummitt, Charisse Fain, Leo Kelly, Jr., and Valencia Perry.

Absent: Commissioner Thomas S. Hester, Jr.

Also present were County Manager C. Renee Perry, Assistant County Manager Jeremy Jones, Finance Director Stephanie Williams, County Attorney Jonathan S. Care, and Clerk to the Board Kelly H. Grissom.

Communications Tower. Henderson City Manager Hassan Kingsberry and Assistant City Manager Paylor Spruill appeared before the board and stated that the city has received a federal grant through the US Department of Housing and Urban Development (HUD) for the purpose of constructing an emergency communications tower. The plan is to construct the tower on a portion of the North Henderson ball field on Birch Street. The application was made in the name of the City of Henderson and resulted in an award of \$2.175M based on a project estimate of \$2.9M, with the city contributing the land and access easement. The award is 75% of the estimated project cost. In a letter to Congressman Don Davis from the former county manager dated March 2023, the county would partner with the city and use the grant funding to construct the tower and install the necessary equipment to join it with the existing VIPER network.

The tower would need to be constructed per the requirements of the NC State Highway Patrol Technical Services Unit with the intent to present the project to the state for perpetual ownership and maintenance. The city and county would become co-location tenants on the tower to the extent other non-VIPER communications are needed such as VHF. Mr. Spruill informed the board that Duke Energy has informally expressed interest in co-location and is willing to construct the project, covering 25% of the direct cost, in return for equitable consideration to be negotiated.

Retired Emergency Operations Director Brian Short appeared before the board in support of the new tower. He stated that this would solve two major problems: in-building coverage in downtown Henderson and VHF paging throughout the county. He noted that the grant should pay for the cost of the actual tower but equipping it with VIPER equipment could cost another \$1M. He also noted that an adjacent tower may need to be constructed in order to hold a dish to receive the signal from the new tower to pair it to the network, or the county could possibly use a tower in Manson to receive the signal. He suggested that the county contact Marty Randall with 10-18 Consulting to assist with the project. It was noted that the city is already using Mr. Randall for this purpose.

Mr. Kingsberry and Mr. Spruill stated that the city is requesting the county to fund 50% of any shortfall after the grant and funding from Duke Energy has been exhausted, but they did not provide an exact amount.

Williams Montgomery Park. Recreation Director Kendrick Vann appeared before the board and stated that a \$715,000 grant was received in 2020 through the NC Parks and Recreation Trust Fund to construct a park on the corner of Williams and Montgomery Streets. Due to COVID, the funding was not released until 2022. The park will consist of a splash pad, walking track, skate park, fitness equipment, two picnic shelters, and bathrooms/showers. Bids were solicited twice, and one response was received in the amount of \$1.8M. This leaves a difference of \$1,085,000. County Manager C. Renee Perry noted that recreation is funded 55% city and 45% county. Commissioner R. Dan Brummitt expressed his concerns and stated that the county currently has several projects that need immediate attention and has limited tax dollars for these projects. Ms. Perry stated that she would look into this matter further and bring her recommended budget to the board on May 5.

Sale of Old Aycock Gym. Ms. Perry informed the board that someone has expressed interest in buying the old Aycock gym on Vicksboro Road. Recreation Director Kendrick Vann stated that this facility is utilized by recreation as an indoor baseball and softball facility with batting cages, pitching mound, and hitting tees. It is also used for storage for off-season sports. Following brief discussion, the board was not interested in selling this facility.

EMS Main Station Land Options. Ms. Perry asked for the board's direction regarding the location of a new EMS main station. She noted that the board discussed this matter last year during a closed session, but no direction was given by the board. Commissioner R. Dan Brummitt asked that heat maps be updated to show where most calls are generated. He also stated that we need to evaluate the need for substations throughout the county. The board discussed the land adjacent to the current EMS station which has restrictive covenants in place. It was noted that the owner of the property has said that these covenants can be removed. This matter will be placed on the May 5 regular meeting agenda to further discuss in closed session.

Rezoning Request – Off NC 39 Hwy South. It was noted that a public hearing was held on this matter during the board's regular March meeting. The board heard public comments and referred the matter to the planning/environmental committee. Committee items are now being addressed during board work sessions. Commissioner R. Dan Brummitt stated that the area in question is highly agricultural and one of the last remaining agricultural areas in the county. Creating a high-density residential subdivision would not be in the best interest of the county. Commissioner Charisse Fain agreed with this. This matter will be placed on the May 5 regular meeting agenda for formal action.

\$30 Water Fee. During the board's April regular meeting, a public comment was made from a resident who signed up for county water in 2014 for a vacant lot that he had hoped to build on in the future. He has been paying the \$30 monthly base fee since that time. He asked the board to forgive the \$30 base fee since he is not receiving water. County Manager C. Renee Perry stated that she has received similar requests from other residents as well. It was noted that the water system was designed based on signups and the county is not able to forgive the base fee. The base fee is used to cover debt service.

At this time, Ms. Perry introduced Marvin Harrison as the new fire chief. Mr. Harrison stated that he looks forward to working with everyone.

As there was no further business, at 5:10 p.m., the work session was adjourned.